

## RATING METHODOLOGY – INVESTMENT COMPANIES

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This rating methodology explains ICRA's approach to rating investment companies<sup>1</sup> and supersedes ICRA's earlier methodology document on this subject, published in January 2023. While this revised version incorporates a few changes intended to provide more clarity on a few aspects, ICRA's overall approach to assessing holding companies remains materially similar.

### Overview

Investment companies are constituted by promoters or sponsor groups<sup>2</sup> to channel their investments into various investee companies that might individually be engaged in related or unrelated businesses. For the scope of this methodology, the investment companies are defined as those that do not have significant operations of their own and depend on investment income and/or divestment of their investments to service their debt and incur other sundry expenses. As the investment companies are designed mainly to hold investments in investee companies, most of their assets are deployed in the form of investments (or loans and advances) in the investee companies. An investment company's ability to raise new debt or refinance existing borrowings tends to hinge strongly on the market value of its investments in investee companies. The objective of forming an investment company could be multifarious, including capital allocation flexibility, tax planning, achieving better cost efficiencies at the enterprise level, and so on, often with the aim of achieving a large scale and business diversification, besides maximisation of the portfolio value.

Investment companies and their associated corporate structures might assume diverse ownership forms, ranging from exercising control on the investee companies (henceforth, the terms investee companies and operating companies have been used interchangeably), either individually or in concert with the sponsors, to not exercising control and merely being financial investors. The list of rating drivers covered in this methodology document is not exhaustive but provides an overall perspective to the lenders, investors, and other market participants on the rating considerations that ICRA usually considers to be the most important. This document describes the attributes of the three forms of investment company structures, which are generally prevalent, and the approach adopted by ICRA to analyse each of these.

<sup>1</sup> As per the SEBI's definition, investment companies are those that earn major revenue from interest and capital appreciation from investments made. Also, as per SEBI's definition, holding companies are those that hold 51% or more equity stake in other companies. In this document, for analytical purposes, investment companies are those that are analysed either under Structure 2 or Structure 3 approaches as defined later in the document. Similarly, holding companies are those that are analysed under Structure 1 approach as defined later in the document.

<sup>2</sup> Henceforth referred to as "sponsors".

## Investment Company Structures

The analytical approach to assessing investment companies depends on their structure, which in turn is governed by the sponsors' objectives. Given below are the salient attributes of some general investment company structures and ICRA's approach to evaluating them.

### Structure 1

The investment company either has the full ownership or holds a majority equity stake with no significant minority shareholder in most of the material operating companies in the Group. The investment company controls the business strategy of these operating companies and enjoys unfettered control over their cash flows. There may be financing, management or operational linkages among the holding and the operating companies. The investment company may have extended or may be willing to extend explicit support (such as guarantees) or extraordinary financial support to the operating entities to facilitate financing or when they face credit or liquidity stress.

**ICRA's approach:** Analysing the consolidated business profile and financial statements of the investment company and the operating companies, along with other factors such as sectoral diversification of cash flows and refinancing ability, to determine the investment company's credit rating.

### Structure 2

The investment company, along with other sponsor companies, either holds a substantial equity stake in most of the material operating companies in the Group, or in case the investment company on its own holds a majority equity stake in the operating companies, there exists a substantial minority shareholder in the operating companies. The investment company, along with other sponsor companies, drives/ significantly influences the business strategy of these operating companies but does not have unfettered control over their cash flows. There may be financing, management or operational linkages among the holding and the operating companies. The holding company may have extended or may be willing to extend explicit support (such as guarantees) or extraordinary financial support to the weaker operating entities to facilitate financing or when those face credit or liquidity stress.

**ICRA's approach:** The investment company's credit rating would principally be tied to the credit quality of the operating companies, while factoring in the diversity of its investments and other standalone factors, most notably its refinancing ability based on the market value of its investments.

### Structure 3

The investment company, along with other sponsor companies, holds non-controlling equity stake in various operating companies. The operating companies' financing and management are separate. The holding company may influence the business strategy of some operating companies via board representation but does not have unfettered control over their cash flows. The holding company is unlikely to extend financial support to the operating entities.

**ICRA's approach:** The investment company's credit rating need not be driven/ constrained by the credit risk of the operating companies. To a great degree, the investment company's rating would be governed by standalone considerations, including the market value of its investments and its ability to achieve profitable divestitures.

## Key Rating Considerations

### Structure 1

**Rating Approach:** In this type of structure, the investment company and its operating subsidiaries are closely integrated, with the investment company exercising a high degree of control on the operating companies. ICRA's approach to analysing such investment companies is no different than what is adopted for rating any "parent" having multiple subsidiaries. The fact that the investment company does not have any (or material) operations of its own, unlike a general "parent", it is inconsequential to the analysis. Thus, ICRA would consolidate the business as well as the financials of the investment company with that of the operating companies to arrive at a Group rating view. In most situations, the consolidated financials, as reported by the investment company are used directly, unless some specific adjustments are required to be made to better reflect the consolidated economic reality. The adjustments could relate to consolidation of certain Group entities to which the investment company might have extended corporate guarantees; or exclusion of select entities that may have been consolidated out of accounting requirements but may otherwise be insulated from Group dynamics because of *inter alia* regulatory reasons, or presence of restrictive debt covenants, or the investment company's (parent's) track record and commitment to extend only limited support to such entities<sup>3</sup>.

The rationale for adopting the consolidation approach is the premise that there is a track record of, or an expectation of, unhindered funding interchanges between the investment company and the operating companies. The investment company and the operating companies might also be tied through cross-guarantees or cross-defaults, implying a more explicit transmission of credit risk among them. As a result, undertaking a consolidated financial statement analysis is more meaningful as this allows looking beyond the legal boundaries among various entities and treating these as representing a single consolidated enterprise, in substance.

**Potential Rating:** The Group rating view, formed upon analysing the consolidated financial statements of the investment company and upon analysing the business risks of the Group, becomes the reference point for assigning final rating to each individual entity.

- » The investment company's credit rating could be the same as the Group rating view.
- » The rating of the individual operating companies may differ depending on their individual credit profiles and their importance to the overall Group strategy but would generally be capped at the Group rating<sup>4</sup>.

### Structure 2

**Rating Approach:** In the second type of structure, while the investment company (along with other sponsor companies) may drive/ significantly influence the business strategy of the operating companies and there may also be financing, management or operational linkages between them, the extent of integration among various companies is limited compared with Structure 1. This may either because of the presence of substantial minority shareholder or lack of a majority equity shareholding of the investment company in the material operating companies. As a result, the investment company does not have unconstrained access to the operating companies' cash flows.

Thus, consolidating the financials of the operating companies with the investment company may not be analytically appropriate. So, a different analytical approach becomes necessary to evaluate such investment company structures. The credit risk of such investment companies, nevertheless, continues to be influenced by the credit quality of their investments and their distinctive ability to leverage based on the market value of their investments, besides their standalone financial risk

<sup>3</sup> For more details, refer to ICRA's methodology titled, "Rating Approach--Consolidation", available on ICRA's website [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in)

<sup>4</sup> For more details on this, refer to ICRA's methodology titled, "Rating Approach--Implicit parent or group support", available on ICRA's website [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in)

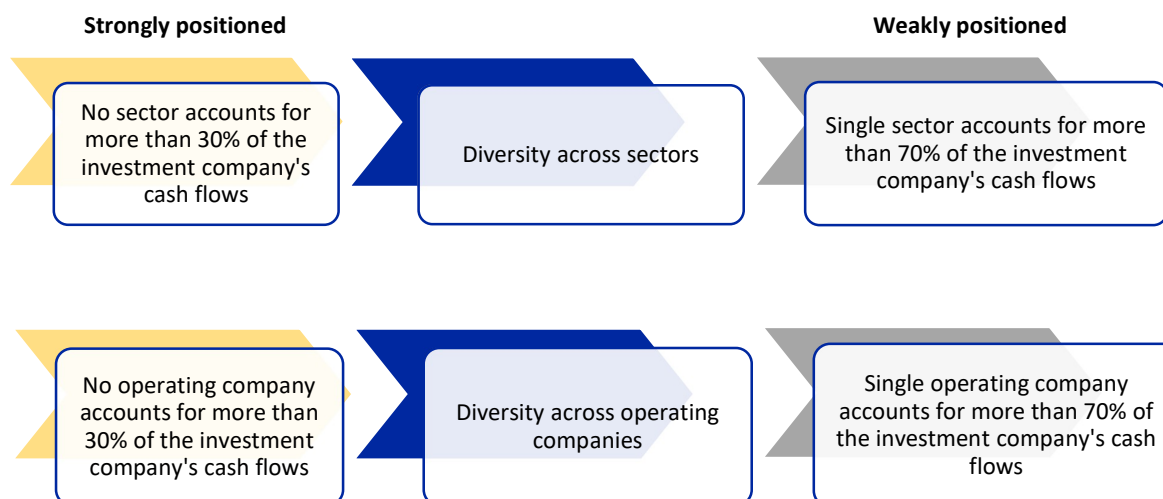
profile. The building blocks of the credit risk assessment framework applied to rate such investment companies is presented below.

|                         |                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business Risk           | Blended credit quality of investees<br>Diversity of investments across sectors and companies                                                      |
| Financial Risk          | Debt coverage<br>Leverage                                                                                                                         |
| Other Parameters        | Financial flexibility and liquidity<br>Investment and financial policies<br>Governance, financial reporting, and disclosures                      |
| Parent or Group Support | Parent's ability and willingness to extend financial support to the investment company out of business, strategic and reputational considerations |

### Determination of Business Risk

**Blended credit quality of investees:** The assessment of Structure 2-type investment companies starts with determining the blended credit quality of the operating companies. As the investment companies depend on the income earned from investees (such as dividends, rents, or royalty) to be able to service their debt and incur sundry expenses, the blended credit quality indicates the sustainability of the income and thereby, is one of the key drivers of the investment companies' rating. ICRA determines the average credit quality of the investees by considering the unsupported rating of the individual operating companies (i.e. the rating that does not factor in the impact of any implicit or explicit external support on the investees' credit profile) and weighing these appropriately.

**Diversity of investments:** As a investment company depends on cash flow streams that are often discretionary (from the investees' perspective), specifically when these relate to dividends, having a diversified investment portfolio across multiple operating companies is viewed favourably from a credit perspective as it mitigates the impact of weakness in any particular operating company. ICRA measures an investment portfolio's diversity in terms of its spread across operating companies and sectors. In case there are multiple operating companies in the same sector, the benefit of diversity in investments is considered only if such individual companies are not co-related (for example, the companies cater to different customers, geographies, or products). This factor tends to have either a positive or a neutral impact on the overall business risk of the investment company, depending on the extent of diversity.



### Determination of Financial Risk

ICRA's assessment of an investment company's financial metrics is based both on the past numbers as well as the projections drawn, besides performing a sensitivity analysis. The following are the two key ratios that ICRA evaluates:

**Debt coverage:** An investment company that consistently reports higher income in relation to its debt servicing obligations does not need to rely on other sources (asset sales, refinancing) to pay off its debt. This is considered a favourable attribute from a credit perspective. ICRA measures the (standalone) debt coverage of an investment company through two indicators viz., interest coverage ratio and debt service coverage ratio<sup>5</sup>. Non-recurring cash flows, such as profit from asset sales, are excluded from these measures, although these are factored into the overall rating assessment.

**Leverage:** Other things being equal, a high leverage invariably implies a high credit risk and vice versa. ICRA measures an investment company's (standalone) leverage through the Total Debt/OPBITDA<sup>6</sup> multiple (where OPBITDA is operating profit before interest, tax, depreciation, and amortisation; and Total Debt is borrowings plus commitments such as guarantees)<sup>6</sup>.

It could be argued that the Total Debt/OPBITDA multiple and debt service coverage ratio are not the best measures of an investment company's leverage and debt servicing capacity as the debt is expected to be refinanced on maturity and hence, repayment of the principal amount does not depend on OPBITDA or cash accruals. However, this ratio allows making a distinction among investment companies that might be critically dependent on refinancing (because of inadequate OPBITDA or cash accruals) versus investment companies that might be reasonably self-sufficient (because of high OPBITDA or cash accruals) to service their debt obligations. The aspect of risk arising from high leverage in relation to OPBITDA or inadequate coverage getting mitigated because of high financial flexibility arising from the market value of investments is taken into consideration separately, as outlined in the next section.

|                      | Strongest    |  | Weakest  |
|----------------------|--------------|--|----------|
| Interest Coverage    | $\geq 18.0x$ |  | $< 2.0x$ |
| DSCR                 | $\geq 4.0x$  |  | $< 1.1x$ |
| Total Debt / OPBITDA | $\leq 0.5x$  |  | $> 5.0x$ |

### Other Parameters

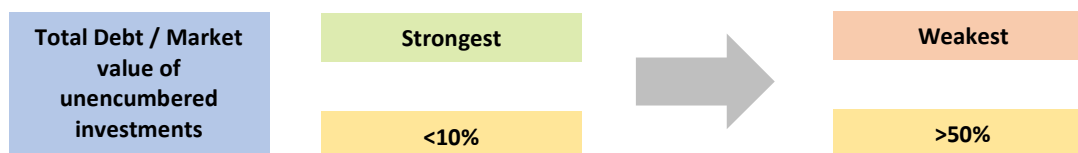
**Financial Flexibility:** One of the key distinguishing features of an investment company is the financial flexibility available to it to take on additional borrowings or refinance existing debt on the back of the market value of its unencumbered investments. ICRA measures the financial flexibility of an investment company by estimating the ratio of its Total Debt to the market value of unencumbered investments. The lower the ratio, higher is the financial flexibility to refinance or raise new debt.

- » While calculating Total Debt, ICRA includes off-balance sheet obligations like corporate guarantees.
- » While estimating the market value of investments, ICRA does not simply go by the prevailing market values but makes suitable adjustments to factor in the equity market's volatile nature.
- » While assessing the financial flexibility, ICRA duly considers that an investment company may not be inclined to encumber the shares it holds in operating companies beyond a threshold, even if those shares might be eligible to be encumbered technically. For example, an investment company having a 60% equity stake in an operating company, might not be keen to encumber its investments beyond 10%, lest it should lose majority control in a worst-case scenario.

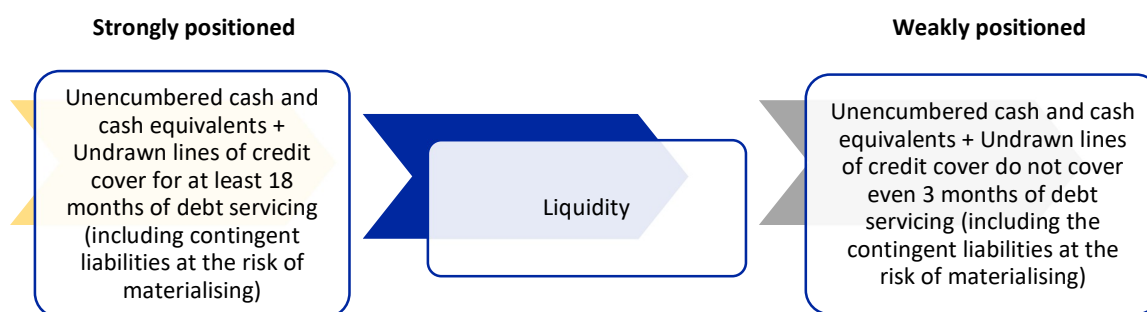
<sup>5</sup> For more details, refer to ICRA's methodology titled, "Rating Approach--Financial Ratio Analysis", available on ICRA's website [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in)

<sup>6</sup> For a holding company, OPBITDA includes dividend, rent or royalty income.

An investment company may have other sources of financial flexibility too, like unencumbered assets, physical or financial (other than the equity shares in operating companies) that could be collateralised, has linkages with a strong sponsor group, or has strong relationship with banks, financial institutions, and other intermediaries, that may allow it to borrow at a short notice. ICRA considers these factors in financial flexibility assessment on a qualitative basis.



**Liquidity:** Maintaining a comfortable liquidity position through on-balance sheet or off-balance sheet resources is essential for any entity, and more so for an investment company, operating cash flows of which, by their very nature, could have a high variability. For assessing the liquidity position of an investment company, ICRA estimates the period for which the unencumbered cash and cash equivalents and undrawn lines of credit cover the upcoming debt servicing obligations. This apart, ICRA evaluates the degree of diversity in funding sources that an investment company has at its disposal. ICRA notes that an investment company may maintain good liquidity, but rather inconsistently, given the trade-off between returns and liquidity. Hence, the overall liquidity assessment is done in the context of the company's policy towards maintaining adequate liquidity<sup>7</sup>. An investment company that has a relatively modest liquidity profile, but a strong refinancing ability, may not necessarily be viewed unfavourably.



**Investment and Financial Policies:** An established track record of making fundamentally sound investments, a generally conservative approach adopted towards growth and investments, and a consistent track record of maintaining low financial leverage are some of the attributes that ICRA assesses to form a view on the sustainability of an investment company's credit profile.

**Governance, Financial Reporting and Disclosures:** ICRA seeks to gain a qualitative understanding of the investment company's commitment to following transparent and credible practices by the way its financial statements are reported, their level of disclosures, consistency in communication and the openness in sharing information during the credit rating exercise, and with other stakeholders in general. Inconsistency in the various forms of information shared, which could be a reflection of weak management information systems, and a general tendency of being opaque in communications are viewed unfavourably.

**Potential Rating:** An investment company's rating (before factoring parent/Group support) would be anchored around the blended credit quality of the operating companies with the extent of notch down from the blended credit quality depending on the investment company's standalone considerations, as elaborated in the sections above.

<sup>7</sup> For more details, refer to ICRA's methodology titled, "Rating Approach--Liquidity Analysis (Non-Financial Sector)", available on ICRA's website [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in)

### Parent or Group Support

If the investment company being rated is the ultimate investment company of the sponsor group, the aspect of its rating being supported or negatively influenced by a parent would not be applicable. However, if the investment company being rated is an intermediate investment company of the sponsor group, ICRA analyses the positive or negative impact that the parent may have on the rated company's credit profile. Such an analysis involves:

- » Assessing the credit quality of the parent, which would be a determinant of its ability to extend financial support to the rated investment company if it faces credit or liquidity stress, and
- » Assessing the importance that the rated investment company holds for the parent out of business, strategic or reputational considerations, which would be a determinant of the parent's willingness to extend financial support to the rated company<sup>8</sup>.

### Structure 3

**Rating Approach:** In the third type of structure, the investment company (along with other sponsor companies) is characterised as one that generally holds non-controlling equity stakes in various operating companies. These structures are limited in the Indian context. This section outlines ICRA's approach to rating Structure 3-type investment companies, where neither the investment company (along with other sponsor companies) exercises control over the cash flows of the operating companies (because of lack of control) nor is it likely to extend distress support to the operating companies, should there be a need. Such investment companies have a greater resemblance to financial investors as opposed to strategic investors—with their business model focused sharply on portfolio value maximisation through monetisation of assets (whenever pertinent) and reinvestment.

Given the distance maintained, the risk of credit contagion between such investment companies and their operating companies is low. Thus, ratings of such investment companies need not be driven by the credit risk of the operating companies. To a great degree, ratings of such investment companies are governed by standalone considerations.

From a rating methodology perspective, ICRA's approach to analysing Structure 3-type investment companies remains broadly similar to that for analysing Structure 2-type investment companies as attributes such as the quality and the diversity of investments/ cash flows are the common considerations in both the structures. However, there is one key point of difference. While the blended credit quality of the investees is an important rating driver for the rating of Structure 2-type investment companies, it is not so for Structure 3-type investment companies. The latter are not as exposed to the credit risk of the investees as they are to the equity risk. The building blocks of the credit risk assessment framework applied to rate such investment companies is presented below.

|                         |                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business Risk           | Diversity of investments                                                                                                                       |
| Financial Risk          | Debt coverage<br>Leverage                                                                                                                      |
| Other Parameters        | Financial flexibility and liquidity<br>Investment and financial policies<br>Governance, financial reporting and disclosures                    |
| Parent or Group Support | Parent's ability and willingness to extend financial support to the holding company out of business, strategic and reputational considerations |

<sup>8</sup> For more details, refer to ICRA's methodology titled, "Rating Approach--Implicit parent or group support", available on ICRA's website [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in)



The explanation on why the above factors matter and what their rating implication is, remain similar to that provided in the previous section of this document.

**Potential Rating:** Given that the rating of a Structure 3-type investment company would be governed essentially by standalone considerations, it is possible that its credit quality is superior to that of the operating companies on the back of high quality of investments, diversification of investment portfolio, strong financial flexibility because of low debt in relation to the market value of unencumbered investments and approach of maintaining arm's length distance from the operating companies with the general lack of commitment to financially support the operating companies at times of stress. These attributes could allow the investment company to maintain significant financial capacity to service its own debt obligations and qualify to be rated higher than the investees, with these strengths more than offsetting the dependence on potentially lower rated operating companies for most of the income.

At the other extreme, if the investment company does not have adequate investment diversification and the fundamentals of the operating companies are also weak, then the quality of the investments also has a bearing on the investment company's rating. This is because of the dependence of the investment company on discretionary dividend payouts from the investees, or divestment of stake in the investees, both of which could get impacted due to weakening of the credit profile of the investees.

## Assessment of Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) Risks

The assessment of ESG risks by ICRA involves a broad range of considerations that pertain to the sustainability of an entity with focus on aspects that can have a material impact on its credit quality. While the E&S risks tend to be both sector-related as well as entity-specific and could be driven by external factors such as regulations or demographic changes, the G risks are largely entity-driven. The impact of the E&S risks on an entity's credit profile tends to be asymmetric. If the ESG risks are material but unmitigated, these generally translate into pulling down the rating, but generally the ratings are not pushed up even when the ESG context is favourable.

### Environmental (E) and Social (S) Risks

As this methodology highlights, while undertaking credit assessment of entities, ICRA seeks to incorporate all relevant credit considerations into its rating decisions, while taking a forward-looking view on the risks and the mitigating elements. The relevant credit considerations include (sometimes overtly, sometimes covertly) the E&S factors that could affect the rated entity/ transaction. While ICRA's analytical approach does not explicitly disaggregate these risks to assess their impact on the rating, these are often assessed broadly, if not precisely. Further, it is not always feasible to fully or precisely disaggregate the sub-components of E&S risks in credit analysis as these considerations often tend to overlap<sup>9</sup>.

However, the materiality of the E&S risks and the time horizon over which they are expected to crystallise differs widely across sectors and entities. In some cases, while the E&S risks could be material, their effect on the credit profile may be muted because of other fundamental strengths of the entity. In other cases, if the adverse impact of the E&S risks is expected to play out in the distant future, these considerations do not necessarily weigh on the rating today — with the expectation that when these risks manifest in the future, the rated entity by then would possibly adapt itself by realigning its business model.

While evaluating the E&S risks, ICRA's objective is only to assess the direct and indirect risks that an entity faces and how it already is or is intending to mitigate the impact of such risks on its credit profile. As an example, ICRA only assesses whether an entity is exposed to physical climate risks, or carbon transition risks or other environmental and social risks; and seeks to understand the various mitigation and adaptation approaches that the entity is implementing to mitigate these risks. Notwithstanding the above, as an example, it is possible that even if an entity A has a higher carbon footprint than entity B, it

<sup>9</sup> For example, carbon-reduction measures by an entity would have positive implications for the health and well-being of the community (an S factor) as well as for reducing greenhouse gas emissions (an E factor).



does not materially affect ICRA's credit opinion on entity A because ICRA's credit opinion considers a wide gamut of credit-relevant factors, and the E&S factors are only some among many.

The investment companies are exposed to environmental risks through their operating companies. If the operating companies face business disruption because of physical climate adversities, or if such businesses face climate transition risks because of technological, regulatory, or customer behaviour changes, it could translate into credit risks for the investment companies. However, the risk can be mitigated via adequate sectoral diversification of the operating companies. Likewise, the exposure of investment companies to social risks depends on the nature of the sectors in which the operating companies are present and the relative concentration of investments.

### Governance Risks

A sound corporate governance structure attempts to make clear the distinction of power and responsibilities between the Board of Directors and the management. The constitution of an entity's Board and the Board of Directors' participation in strategy formulation, besides the entity's adherence to legal and statutory compliance requirements are factored in during credit assessments. ICRA seeks to gain a qualitative understanding of an entity's commitment to following transparent and credible practices by the way its financial statements are reported, their level of disclosures, consistency in communication and the openness about sharing information during the credit rating exercise. Besides, the corporate group structure (whether simple or complex), the rated entity's related party transactions, and instances of supporting group entities at the expense of debt holders are assessed.

## Summing Up

This document discusses the various factors that are generally evaluated by ICRA to determine an investment company's credit rating. The rating approach may differ depending on the type of the investment company structure being evaluated. While the document describes the attributes of three broad investment company structures and the approach adopted by ICRA to analyse these, the eventual approach adopted to arrive at rating decisions may not always fit in one single approach. The investment company structures could be disparate and often the analytical approach might require improvisation on a case-by-case basis. Nevertheless, this document should serve as a reference for lenders, investors, and other market participants to understand the general principles that ICRA follows for rating investment companies.

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#### About ICRA Limited:

ICRA Limited was set up in 1991 by leading financial/investment institutions, commercial banks and financial services companies as an independent and professional investment Information and Credit Rating Agency.

Today, ICRA and its subsidiaries together form the ICRA Group of Companies (Group ICRA). ICRA is a Public Limited Company, with its shares listed on the Bombay Stock Exchange and the National Stock Exchange. The international Credit Rating Agency Moody's Investors Service is ICRA's largest shareholder.

For more information, visit [www.icra.in](http://www.icra.in) and [www.icraresearch.in](http://www.icraresearch.in)

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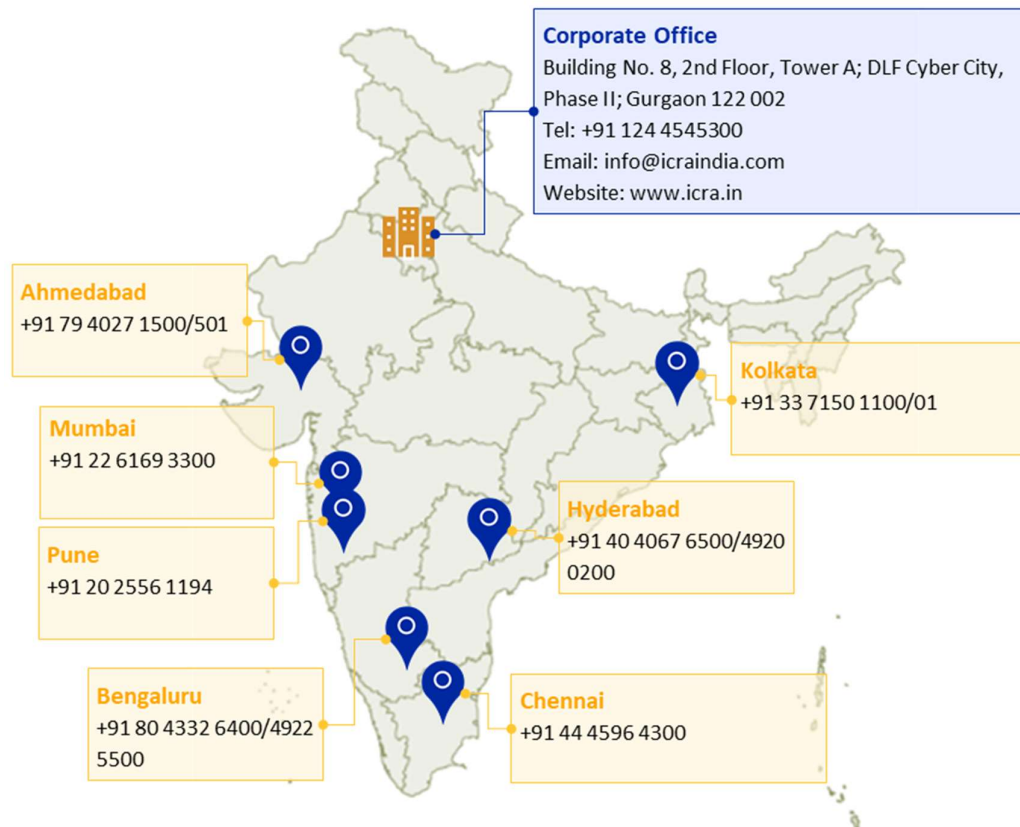
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### Branches



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